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PNIMA Israel — Reducing Polarization
Building Social Cohesion and Long-Term National Resilience

Executive Summary

Polarization has become one of the most defining challenges facing Israeli society, shaping public discourse, weakening trust in institutions, and limiting the country's ability to respond effectively to national crises. While widely recognized as a critical issue, efforts to address polarization have often remained fragmented and reactive.

PNIMA is leading the development of a comprehensive national framework aimed at addressing polarization in a structured and long-term way. By moving from isolated initiatives to a coordinated strategy grounded in research, policy, and implementation, this work seeks to strengthen social cohesion and rebuild the shared foundations necessary for a resilient society.

The Challenge

Polarization in Israel is not a single phenomenon but a complex and reinforcing dynamic that operates across multiple dimensions. Emotional polarization manifests as distrust and hostility between groups; ideological polarization reflects deep and often uncompromising value-based disagreements; and social polarization is expressed through increasing separation and lack of shared spaces.

These dynamics unfold across key arenas, including political leadership, public institutions, media and social networks, and the broader public. Together, they create a cycle in which declining trust, institutional weakness, and social fragmentation reinforce one another, making it increasingly difficult to address core national challenges.

Our Solution

PNIMA's approach begins with building a shared understanding of the problem. The organization has developed a comprehensive knowledge framework that maps the different types of polarization and the arenas in which they operate, providing a structured basis for analysis and action.

Building on this foundation, PNIMA is advancing the development of a national strategy that translates this knowledge into practical policy pathways. This includes

identifying targeted interventions for different forms of polarization, aligning stakeholders across sectors, and creating a coherent framework that can guide government and civil society efforts over time.

The process combines international comparative research, the work of expert groups, and ongoing engagement with policymakers and practitioners, with the goal of ensuring that the resulting strategy is both conceptually robust and practically implementable.

Impact to Date

This work has already begun to shift the way polarization is understood and addressed in Israel. The development of a shared knowledge base has created a common language for policymakers and stakeholders, while partnerships with leading institutions have helped position polarization as a central strategic issue rather than a peripheral concern.

At the same time, the process has laid the groundwork for coordinated action, bringing together diverse actors and building the relationships necessary to support long-term implementation.

Strategic Vision

The long-term goal is to move Israel from fragmented and reactive responses to polarization toward a coordinated national strategy that addresses its root causes. This includes embedding polarization as a core policy issue, integrating responses across sectors, and building sustained capacity to manage societal divisions over time.

Such a shift would not eliminate disagreement, but would strengthen the ability of Israeli society to navigate deep differences while maintaining a shared foundation for collective action.

Funding Opportunity

Support for this initiative will first and foremost enable the advancement of a comprehensive national policy framework, including the development of actionable policy alternatives and the integration of polarization as a central issue within government decision-making processes.

In parallel, it will support the continued work with key stakeholders—including government actors, civil society organizations, and thought leaders—to translate

strategy into coordinated action and build the infrastructure required for implementation across sectors.

Finally, support will enable the expansion of research, field engagement, and pilot initiatives that test and refine practical approaches to reducing polarization, ensuring that the strategy is grounded in real-world application and capable of generating measurable impact over time.

Why It Matters

The opposite of polarization is not uniformity, it is resilience. The ability of a diverse society to sustain disagreement while maintaining a shared foundation for action. Strengthening that capacity is essential not only for social cohesion, but for the long-term stability and future of Israel as a democratic and inclusive society.